

# A Conceptual Primer on Learning Beyond Pure Chaining

Credal Beliefs, Representation Growth, and Cognitive Synergy

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## Abstract

This note develops a conceptual answer to a central question in symbolic probabilistic reasoning: what should a system do when pure chaining no longer recovers the right belief state? The answer proposed here is not to abandon reasoning, but to embed it in a richer learning architecture. The key move is to recognize that additive or local chaining succeeds only on a restricted fragment, while realistic partially observable environments force one to track beliefs over hidden structure, ambiguity over models, and the value of constructing better internal representations.

The note argues for a five-part picture. First, pure chaining must be given a sharp semantic boundary. Second, hidden-state ambiguity should be represented credally rather than collapsed prematurely to a single scalar. Third, learning should search for better sufficient statistics, better latent variables, and better compression maps rather than merely tuning local rule weights. Fourth, limited computation should be managed by attention and value-of-information policies. Fifth, these mechanisms should compose in a cognitively synergistic way: symbolic chaining, Bayesian belief tracking, imprecise belief representation, representation learning, and attention control should each repair the others' blind spots instead of competing for a single universal formalism.

## Contents

|          |                                                            |          |
|----------|------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| <b>1</b> | <b>Purpose and scope</b>                                   | <b>2</b> |
| <b>2</b> | <b>The boundary of pure chaining</b>                       | <b>3</b> |
| 2.1      | What pure chaining is good at . . . . .                    | 3        |
| 2.2      | What breaks . . . . .                                      | 3        |
| 2.3      | The methodological lesson . . . . .                        | 3        |
| <b>3</b> | <b>Belief state rather than derived edge</b>               | <b>3</b> |
| 3.1      | The first conceptual shift . . . . .                       | 3        |
| 3.2      | The second shift . . . . .                                 | 4        |
| <b>4</b> | <b>Credal beliefs as the first learning-aware response</b> | <b>4</b> |
| 4.1      | Why credal semantics comes first . . . . .                 | 4        |
| 4.2      | Why this matters for symbolic systems . . . . .            | 4        |
| 4.3      | A conceptual interpretation of confidence . . . . .        | 4        |
| <b>5</b> | <b>Learning as sufficient-statistic discovery</b>          | <b>5</b> |
| 5.1      | The basic idea . . . . .                                   | 5        |
| 5.2      | What this means concretely . . . . .                       | 5        |
| 5.3      | Why this is better than “fixing the formulas” . . . . .    | 5        |

|           |                                                                |           |
|-----------|----------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| <b>6</b>  | <b>Learning as latent-variable construction</b>                | <b>5</b>  |
| 6.1       | From hidden-state recovery to latent-state invention . . . . . | 5         |
| 6.2       | Why this matters . . . . .                                     | 5         |
| 6.3       | A key consequence . . . . .                                    | 6         |
| <b>7</b>  | <b>Learning as attention and belief compression</b>            | <b>6</b>  |
| 7.1       | The computational problem . . . . .                            | 6         |
| 7.2       | Attention as a first-class epistemic policy . . . . .          | 6         |
| 7.3       | Why this is not merely approximation . . . . .                 | 6         |
| <b>8</b>  | <b>Learning as meta-inference</b>                              | <b>6</b>  |
| 8.1       | Beliefs about filters . . . . .                                | 6         |
| 8.2       | Why this is attractive . . . . .                               | 6         |
| 8.3       | The conceptual payoff . . . . .                                | 7         |
| <b>9</b>  | <b>A cognitively synergistic architecture</b>                  | <b>7</b>  |
| 9.1       | Why no single mechanism is enough . . . . .                    | 7         |
| 9.2       | The synergy stack . . . . .                                    | 7         |
| 9.3       | The conceptual moral . . . . .                                 | 7         |
| <b>10</b> | <b>Where learning should enter in world-model reasoning</b>    | <b>7</b>  |
| 10.1      | Before chaining . . . . .                                      | 7         |
| 10.2      | During chaining . . . . .                                      | 8         |
| 10.3      | After chaining . . . . .                                       | 8         |
| <b>11</b> | <b>What this implies for POMDP-capable reasoning</b>           | <b>8</b>  |
| 11.1      | The planning connection . . . . .                              | 8         |
| 11.2      | The practical implication . . . . .                            | 8         |
| 11.3      | The conservative universal-prediction leg . . . . .            | 8         |
| <b>12</b> | <b>A theorem-shaped research program</b>                       | <b>9</b>  |
| <b>13</b> | <b>A compact primer for future conversations</b>               | <b>9</b>  |
| <b>14</b> | <b>Conclusion</b>                                              | <b>10</b> |

# 1 Purpose and scope

This article is a companion to a broader primer on world-model Markov, hidden Markov, and POMDP reasoning. Its focus is narrower and more strategic:

If pure symbolic probabilistic chaining does not fully solve the reasoning problem, where should learning enter?

The goal is not to replace semantic reasoning with statistical heuristics. Rather, the aim is to describe a layered architecture in which learning enters precisely where chaining reaches principled limits.

The note is written as a conceptual primer for future work and future conversations. It therefore emphasizes design commitments, failure modes, and research directions rather than implementation detail.

## 2 The boundary of pure chaining

### 2.1 What pure chaining is good at

Pure chaining is strongest in settings where:

- the semantic model is explicit,
- local composition rules are exact under known side conditions,
- or the posterior state admits an additive sufficient statistic.

In such cases, local symbolic or evidence-carrying reasoning can be exact, transparent, and computationally attractive.

### 2.2 What breaks

The boundary appears when the system is asked to reason through hidden variables, partial observability, or underdetermined latent structure. Then one encounters at least four kinds of failure.

1. **Non-identifiability:** different latent models induce the same observed law.
2. **State uncertainty:** what matters for action is a posterior over hidden states, not a directly observed symbol frequency.
3. **Representation mismatch:** the currently chosen predicates or symbols are not sufficient statistics for the real task.
4. **Resource limits:** even when the semantics is clear, exact inference may be too expensive to run exhaustively.

### 2.3 The methodological lesson

**Principle 1** (Boundary honesty). *When pure chaining ceases to be semantically faithful, the right response is not to stretch its formulas beyond their domain. The right response is to change the representation, the uncertainty object, the computational policy, or all three.*

This point is subtle. It does not say symbolic reasoning is obsolete. It says symbolic reasoning must be embedded in a richer architecture that can learn better representations, maintain ambiguity honestly, and choose what to compute next.

## 3 Belief state rather than derived edge

### 3.1 The first conceptual shift

The first shift beyond pure chaining is from *derived edge confidence* to *belief state*. In a partially observable system, the operative question is usually not:

What scalar truth value should I attach to this next symbolic consequence?

but rather:

What posterior state over hidden structure should guide action, prediction, and further inference?

This is the fundamental contribution of filtering in hidden-state models and of belief-state semantics in POMDPs.

### 3.2 The second shift

The second shift is from *single posterior state* to *set of possible posterior states*. When observations underdetermine latent structure, belief itself is ambiguous. A single posterior number can be a lossy and misleading summary.

## 4 Credal beliefs as the first learning-aware response

### 4.1 Why credal semantics comes first

The most direct response to non-identifiability is a credal one. If multiple hidden models remain compatible with the same observations, then the hidden belief should be represented as a set or interval, not as a point estimate chosen too early.

**Definition 1** (Credal latent belief). *Given a family of compatible latent models  $\Theta$  and an observation history  $h$ , the credal belief over a latent query  $q$  is the interval*

$$\left[ \inf_{\theta \in \Theta} P_{\theta}(q \mid h), \sup_{\theta \in \Theta} P_{\theta}(q \mid h) \right].$$

### 4.2 Why this matters for symbolic systems

This move is important because it turns a no-go result into a usable semantic object.

Positive example:

- if two hidden-state models agree on all observations but disagree maximally on a latent-state query, the correct answer is the full interval from 0 to 1.

Negative example:

- a single scalar “confidence” may hide the fact that the posterior is structurally ambiguous rather than merely noisy.

### 4.3 A conceptual interpretation of confidence

In this setting, confidence is no longer best interpreted as a primitive extra field attached to every inference step. A deeper interpretation is:

Confidence reflects the width, stability, or fragility of the compatible belief set induced by the current observations and assumptions.

This connects credal semantics to the older symbolic intuition that truth value should include both strength and confidence, but it grounds that distinction in hidden-model ambiguity rather than in an ad hoc numeric convention.

## 5 Learning as sufficient-statistic discovery

### 5.1 The basic idea

When the current observable symbols are not sufficient for the task, one should learn derived observables, summary statistics, or latent predicates that make the problem more identifiable or more decision-relevant.

**Principle 2** (Representation before weight fitting). *When pure chaining fails because the currently visible vocabulary is insufficient, the first learning move should be to improve the representation, not merely to retune local rule weights.*

### 5.2 What this means concretely

This can take several forms.

- Learn history features that better predict latent mode or future value.
- Learn abstract predicates that summarize long observational traces.
- Learn context-sensitive sufficient statistics for special subdomains.
- Learn regime detectors that decide which local reasoning laws are safe in the present situation.

### 5.3 Why this is better than “fixing the formulas”

If the failure comes from omitted structure, then stretching a local chaining formula will not recover what the representation never recorded. The proper repair is to make the missing structure visible, either explicitly or through a better learned surrogate.

## 6 Learning as latent-variable construction

### 6.1 From hidden-state recovery to latent-state invention

Another conceptual step is to stop assuming that the true latent state space is already known. In many real problems, the best internal state is not recovered from the world but constructed by the agent to improve prediction and action.

**Definition 2** (Constructed latent state). *A constructed latent state is an internal variable introduced because it compresses history in a way that improves future prediction, control, or explanation, even if it does not correspond one-to-one with a unique external hidden variable.*

### 6.2 Why this matters

This move changes the problem from:

Which latent state is really there?

to:

Which internal latent variables make reasoning and action more effective?

That reframing is especially important under persistent non-identifiability. One need not solve metaphysical uniqueness in order to construct a useful belief-state architecture.

### 6.3 A key consequence

If latent variables are allowed to be constructed rather than merely recovered, then learning enters not only as parameter estimation but also as ontology growth. The system may decide that its current symbolic vocabulary is too poor for the task and extend it.

## 7 Learning as attention and belief compression

### 7.1 The computational problem

Even when the correct belief state is well-defined, tracking it exactly may be too expensive. So another place for learning is not the semantics itself but the *compression policy* deciding which parts of belief to maintain faithfully.

### 7.2 Attention as a first-class epistemic policy

An attention mechanism can be understood as a learned projection

$$\text{Bel} \mapsto \widehat{\text{Bel}}$$

that preserves action-relevant distinctions while forgetting the rest.

**Principle 3** (Value-sensitive compression). *A belief-compression map should be evaluated not by whether it preserves all semantic distinctions, but by whether it preserves the distinctions that matter for high-value decisions.*

### 7.3 Why this is not merely approximation

This is not just “cheap inference.” It is a principled architectural layer: the system learns what latent distinctions are worth maintaining under limited time and memory. In that sense, attention is a learned epistemic policy over belief state.

## 8 Learning as meta-inference

### 8.1 Beliefs about filters

One can go a step further and treat the update rule itself as uncertain. Then learning no longer tunes only model parameters; it compares alternative inference procedures, representation choices, and latent constructions.

### 8.2 Why this is attractive

This matters because real systems are often uncertain not just about the world but about:

- which model family is appropriate,
- which latent vocabulary is worth using,
- which summary statistics are sufficient,
- and which approximation policy best trades off cost and fidelity.

### 8.3 The conceptual payoff

Learning can then be read as model selection and update-rule selection at the same time. A reasoning system is not merely updating beliefs inside a fixed formal shell; it is learning which shell best supports competent behavior.

## 9 A cognitively synergistic architecture

### 9.1 Why no single mechanism is enough

Pure chaining fails on hidden structure. Exact Bayesian filtering is often too expensive or too brittle under model mismatch. Credal semantics preserves ambiguity but does not on its own invent better latent states. Representation learning may discover useful features but can lose interpretability. Attention compression manages cost but risks forgetting the wrong thing.

The right picture is therefore not replacement but composition.

### 9.2 The synergy stack

A coherent learning-aware world-model architecture might include:

1. **Exact symbolic/evidence reasoning** on fragments where the model really supports it.
2. **Belief-state tracking** for hidden-state semantics.
3. **Credal belief representation** when observations leave latent structure underdetermined.
4. **Representation learning** to discover more useful summaries, predicates, or latent variables.
5. **Attention and compression** to allocate finite computation toward action-relevant distinctions.
6. **Meta-level selection** over models, filters, and reasoning modes.

### 9.3 The conceptual moral

**Principle 4** (Cognitive synergy). *The role of learning is not merely to replace symbolic reasoning with a more flexible black box. Its deeper role is to supply missing representations, missing statistics, and missing control policies exactly where symbolic chaining reaches principled semantic limits.*

## 10 Where learning should enter in world-model reasoning

The following decomposition is especially useful.

### 10.1 Before chaining

Learning can enter before chaining by improving the representation:

- feature discovery,
- latent construction,
- regime detection,
- and vocabulary growth.

## 10.2 During chaining

Learning can enter during chaining by controlling:

- which rules to attempt,
- which contexts to reveal,
- which belief dimensions to maintain,
- and when to abstain.

## 10.3 After chaining

Learning can enter after chaining by revising:

- which model family remains credible,
- which latent variables are worth preserving,
- and which approximation policy is acceptable under observed error.

# 11 What this implies for POMDP-capable reasoning

## 11.1 The planning connection

In partially observable control, the natural hidden-state object is the belief state. A symbolic world-model system that wants to reason honestly in this setting should therefore:

- track or approximate filtering and smoothing objects,
- carry ambiguity credally when hidden-state models are underdetermined,
- and learn belief compressions or latent refinements that improve action quality.

## 11.2 The practical implication

Learning beyond pure chaining is therefore not optional decoration. It is the mechanism that turns a symbolic reasoning substrate into an architecture capable of operating under partial observability, ambiguity, and finite resources.

## 11.3 The conservative universal-prediction leg

One useful new consequence is that the POMDP-facing story is no longer only about posterior semantics. Along any fixed action stream, a controlled hidden Markov law can now be compared against a concrete controlled Solomonoff-style semimeasure obtained by lifting the ordinary observation-alphabet universal mixture and ignoring actions. This is deliberately conservative, but it is already enough to connect ambiguity-aware belief tracking to finite-horizon log-loss guarantees.

The conceptual lesson is important:

- universal prediction can be attached first at the level of fixed action streams;
- this already yields meaningful regret guarantees for partially observable control;



- and the remaining gap is no longer “whether a bridge exists” but whether one wants a genuinely action-aware universal mixture rather than the current conservative comparator.

The lower-semicomputability hypothesis in that theorem is also conceptually honest. A raw hidden-state parameter object with arbitrary probability measures is not automatically computable. So a learning architecture that wants to reason with universal predictors should expose a computable or lower-semicomputable model subclass explicitly instead of suppressing the domain condition.

## 12 A theorem-shaped research program

The following research directions are especially coherent.

1. **Credal latent belief theorems.** Formalize lower and upper filtering and smoothing beliefs for families of hidden models.
2. **Computable hidden-model classes.** Package model families whose induced observation laws are lower semicomputable, so universal prediction bounds apply without extra ad hoc hypotheses.
3. **Representation-growth semantics.** State what it means for a learned latent variable or predicate to improve identifiability or value.
4. **Belief-compression theorems.** Prove conditions under which a learned compressed belief state preserves action ranking or bounded loss.
5. **Value-of-information policies.** Formalize when revealing more context is worth its cost.
6. **Mode-switching semantics.** Specify when the system should rely on exact chaining, posterior inference, credal intervals, or learned compression.
7. **Meta-filter learning.** Formalize the selection of update rules or model families based on predictive performance and decision quality.

## 13 A compact primer for future conversations

Future work can take the following as a stable conceptual baseline.

1. Pure chaining is exact only on a restricted semantic fragment.
2. Hidden-state reasoning requires belief states, not merely derived local supports.
3. Non-identifiability should be represented credally, not hidden.
4. Learning should improve representations before merely retuning rule parameters.
5. Constructed latent variables are often more important than recovery of a uniquely “true” hidden state.
6. Attention is best understood as a learned value-sensitive belief compression policy.
7. The most powerful architecture is synergistic: symbolic reasoning, Bayesian belief tracking, credal semantics, representation learning, attention, and meta-level control each repair the others’ failure modes.

8. In POMDP-like settings, learning beyond pure chaining is the route from local symbolic inference to competent action under ambiguity.
9. A conservative controlled Solomonoff comparator already gives a first universal-prediction anchor for that route, even before a fully action-aware universal mixture exists.

## 14 Conclusion

The right response to the limitations of pure chaining is not surrender, and it is not unlimited confidence in larger learned models. The right response is a clean architecture in which symbolic reasoning, probabilistic belief tracking, imprecise uncertainty, learned representation growth, and attention control are all given distinct and principled roles.

From this perspective, learning enters exactly where it should:

- to discover better sufficient statistics,
- to build more useful latent variables,
- to preserve ambiguity honestly,
- to compress belief under resource limits,
- and to choose which reasoning mode should be active at all.

That picture preserves the strongest virtues of symbolic world-model reasoning while acknowledging the realities of hidden structure, partial observability, and finite computation. It therefore provides a coherent foundation for learning-aware WM-PLN and POMDP-capable world-model reasoning.